A NEW MOTHERS GUIDE

# A Guide to Daily Nutrition During Pregnancy for those on Speciality Diets



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# Table of Contents


**Do I need to eat more now that I'm expecting?** 4
How much energy do pregnant women need each day?

**What key nutrients do I need during pregnancy?** 5
Protein | Folate | Iron | Iodine | Vitamin D | Calcium | Vitamin B6

**How do I get all the nutrients I need to grow a healthy human?** 8

**What constitutes a serve?** 9
Grains | Fruit | Vegetables | Dairy | Meat & Alternatives

**How much weight should I gain through pregnancy?** 11
How to calculate your BMI

**How to maintain a healthy weight during pregnancy** 12
How can i monitor my weight gain?
What if I'm not gaining enough weight?
What if I'm gaining too much weight?

**Quick tips to manage your weight gain during pregnancy** 14

**Healthy snack ideas** 15

**Frequently Asked Questions** 16
What foods should I avoid eating during pregnancy?
Vitamin and mineral supplementation for pregnancy
What types of fish are safe to eat during pregnancy?
Can I drink alcohol when I am pregnant?
Can I have drinks containing caffeine?

**A note from Kat** 19



# A Guide to Daily Nutrition During Pregnancy for those on Speciality Diet

If you are reading this, you are either trying for a baby or expecting one, so congratulations! Pregnancy may be a very exciting time for you, but it can also be a stressful one where you feel out of control and things are moving quickly. You're undoubtedly feeling vulnerable and totally responsible for the new life inside you, not wanting to muck anything up in any manner, and wanting to do all you can to ensure your baby grows and develops as healthily as possible.

One way you can ensure the healthy development of your baby is to follow a healthy diet, and this can be done even on specialty diets. For example, do you follow a vegan or vegetarian diet? Are there any allergies or restrictions such as gluten free, dairy free or keto to what you can eat?

Whatever the circumstances, it's critical to understand how these changes might influence your nutritional demands so you can ensure that both mother and baby are getting all they require. At Kat Ridout Nutrition, we aim to provide guidance on how women can still get all the nutrients needed while pregnant no matter what speciality diet they may follow.



# Do I need to eat more now that I'm expecting?

In short, NO. The old 'eating for two' idea is incorrect. While pregnant women generally need to consume more of most vitamins and minerals, the quantity of food that you consume during pregnancy should not change much. That means that you will need to increase the nutritional quality of the foods you are eating in order to get all the nutrients that you and your baby need. I'll explain how you can achieve this in my "How do I get all the nutrients I need to grow a healthy human?" section detailed further below.

## How much energy do pregnant women need each day?

Energy requirements for pregnant women vary significantly between women, depending on their level of activity, stage of pregnancy, body composition and pre-pregnancy BMI. In general if you are at a healthy BMI before becoming pregnant, you need between 9200 kJ (2,200 calories) and 12130 kJ (2,900 calories) a day when expecting.

You do not require any extra calories during the first trimester

During the second and third trimesters, women only need an extra 1250kJ (300 calories) per day – which is no more than a banana and a small tub of yoghurt.

Don't hesitate to contact Katrin Ridout Nutrition to help you work out a good plan for how you can achieve this and incorporate all the nutrients you need for a healthy pregnancy. Or if you want a shortcut and fail proof way to ensure you are getting all the nutrition you need, check out my pregnancy menu plans, where all the hard work has been done for you by a team of accredited practicing dietitians and nutritionists.

# What key nutrients do I need?

Your body is going through a lot of changes and has increased demands when you are growing a baby. Good nutrition during pregnancy is essential. More of certain nutrients are required for your own health as well as for optimal growth and development of your bub. Important nutrients during pregnancy include protein, folate, iron, iodine, Vitamin D, and Vitamin B6.

## Protein

Protein is used to grow a baby's tissue, vital organs and brain. It also helps a mother's breast and uterine tissue to grow healthily during pregnancy and it plays a role in your increasing blood supply.

It is recommended that pregnant women consume 75 to 100 grams of protein per day (approximately 2-3 servings of meat or non-meat alternatives such as legumes or nuts (1 serve = approximately 85 g or the size of your palm)

Sources may include fully cooked fish or seafood, chicken, lean beef, lamb pork, nuts, tofu.

## Folate

Folate is a B-group vitamin which is especially important for women of childbearing age. It's important for normal growth and development especially in unborn babies where it helps the nervous system develop. Getting enough folate is critical in the months prior to pregnancy and during the first three months of pregnancy.

During the early stages of pregnancy, babies grow rapidly. In the first four to six weeks of pregnancy, the neural tube closed and fuses, and later becomes the baby's brain and spinal cord. A diet deficient in folate can increase the chances of the neural tube not closing properly, which can result in a neural tube defect, such as spina bifida.

Folate can be found in two forms, either as folate or folic acid. Folate occurs naturally found in green leafy vegetables (such as spinach, broccoli and asparagus), fruits (such as strawberries, oranges and bananas), and legumes (such as chickpeas beans and lentils). Folic acid is a form of folate that is added to foods such as cereal and cereal based products and some fruit juices (but check the food label as not all cereals and fruit juices are fortified with this vitamin).

Lucky for us Aussies, it is now mandatory for all wheat flour used for bread making in Australia to contain folic acid, so unless you make your own or buy organic, eating bread is a great way to boost your folate intake.

**Please note however, that most women do not get enough folate from their diet, so as well as eating foods rich in folate, a daily supplement contacting 500mcg (0.5mg) folic acid is recommended to ensure you are getting enough.**

**If there is a family history of cleft lip, primal problems or you are taking an anti-epilepsy medication, this dose may need to be greater. Please discuss this with your GP*

# What key nutrients do I need?

## Iron

Iron is needed to make red blood cells that carry oxygen around the body. During pregnancy you need more iron because the developing foetus draws iron from the mother to last it through the first five or six months after birth. Not getting enough iron during pregnancy can increase the risk of pre-term deliveries and low-birth weight infants. The recommended daily intake (RD) of iron during pregnant is 27 mg a day (9mg a day more than for nonpregnant women).

Iron losses are reduced during pregnancy, because the woman is no longer menstruating, however, this is not enough to offset the need of the developing foetus. It is therefore important for pregnant women to eat iron-rich foods every day.

Animal sources of iron are readily absorbed by the body. Iron from plant sources is not absorbed as easily, but absorption is helped when these foods are eaten together with foods that contain vitamin C (such as oranges). This is important for women who follow a vegetarian diet. Also, avoiding caffeine at meal-times, can help you to absorb the iron contained in food. Some women can't get enough iron from food, so you may need to take an iron supplement. Your GP or dietitian can recommend what you will need and ensure you don't take too much as iron can be toxic (poisonous) in large amounts.

## Iodine

Iodine is another nutrient that is important for your baby's brain development.

It is needed for the production of thyroid hormone, which is important for growth and development. If you don't have enough iodine during pregnancy, it increases your baby's risk of mental impairment and congenital hypothyroidism.

Marine foods and iodised salt can be valuable contributors – but increasing your salt intake is not recommended. Fortunately, similarly to folate, Australian bread-making flours, including those used to make gluten-free bread, are now fortified with iodine (the exceptions are organic and some yeast-free breads).

Other foods that are good sources of iodine include: seafood, seaweed, eggs, meat, dairy products, commercially sold bread (except organic and unleavened bread).

As well as including foods rich in iodine in your diet, taking a pregnancy multivitamin that contains 150mcg of iodine per day is recommended for women planning a pregnancy, throughout pregnancy and while breastfeeding.

# What key nutrients do I need?

## Vitamin D

Vitamin D is essential for your baby's growth and development and your own health during pregnancy. Vitamin D helps to develop of your baby's bones and teeth and low levels can cause muscle weakness and pain in pregnant women.

Fortunately, we get most of our Vitamin D from the sun. Ultraviolet (UV) radiation from the sun produces vitamin D in the skin and is the best source of vitamin D. We can also absorb a small amount from foods like oily fish, egg yolks, margarine and some brands or milk.

You may be vitamin D deficient if you:

- Have darker skin
- Cover most of your body with clothing
- Spend most of your time indoors

If you fit into one of these categories, it is important to discuss this with your GP, who can order a vitamin D test on your blood and suggest a supplement while you are pregnant and breastfeeding.

## Calcium

Calcium helps your body regulate fluids, and it helps to build your baby's bones.

Amazingly, your calcium requirements don't increase during pregnancy although the baby has a high requirement for calcium during the third trimester of pregnancy (as it starts to develop and strengthen its bones), a mother's body absorbs calcium much better during pregnancy which means that there is no need for extra intake.

The RDI for non-pregnant women (1000mg per day for women ages 19-50 years, and 1300mg a day for adolescents or those aged over 51) remains unchanged during pregnancy and breastfeeding.

To ensure you are meeting your RDI for dairy in general, foods such as milk, cheese, and yoghurt and calciumfortified soy milk are excellent dietary sources of calcium.

## Vitamin B6

Increased blood volume during pregnancy is the major reason vitamin B6 requirements are higher. Deficiency has been linked with pre-eclampsia or hypertension in pregnancy, excessive vomiting, and it may also impact on infant brain development. However, vitamin B6 is readily available in fortified breakfast cereals, vegetables, fruits and meats, so a balanced diet should easily ensure an adequate intake.



# How do I get all the nutrients I need to grow a healthy human?

The main theme for nutrition during pregnancy is **"quality over quantity".**

The Australian Guide to Health eating recommends that women consume a variety of food from the 5 core food groups: **Grains, Dairy, Meat and alternatives, Fruit and Vegetables.**

The following table shows the number of recommended serves for each core food group each day for pregnant women aged 19-50 years:

| Recommended average daily number of serves from each of the five food groups* | | | | | | Additional serves from taller or more active women |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Womans Age** | **Grain (Cereal) foods** | **Dairy** | **Meat & Alternatives** | **Fruit** | **Vegetables & Legumes** | **Womans Additional serves from the five food groups or discretionary choices** |
| **19-50** | **6** | **2 ½** | **2 ½** | **2** | **5** | **0 - 2 ½** |
| **51-70** | **4** | **4** | **2** | **2** | **5** | **0 - 2 ½** |
| **70+** | **3** | **4** | **2** | **2** | **5** | **0 - 2** |
| **Pregnant** | 8 ½ | 2 ½ | 3 ½ | 2 | 5 | 0 - 2 ½ |
| **Lactating** | 9 | 6 | 2 ½ | 2 | 7 | 0 - 2 ½ |

**Includes an allowance for unsaturated spreads or oils, nuts or seeds (2 serves (14-20g) per day for women)*

# What constitutes as a serve?

## Grains (Bread and cereals)

*a standard serve is about 500kJ*

- 1 slice bread
- ½ medium bread roll or flat bread/ wrap
- ½ cup cooked rice, pasta, noodles, buckwheat, polenta, semolina, quinoa

*Grain (cereal) foods, mostly wholegrain and / or high cereal fibre varieties





## Fruit

*a standard serve is about 150g (350kJ)*

- 1 medium apple, banana, orange or pear
- 2 small apricots, kiwi fruits or plums
- 1 cup diced or canned fruit (with no added sugar)
- Or only occasionally
- 125ml or ½ cup fruit juice with no added sugar
- 30g dried fruit (1.e. 4 dried apricots, or 1 ½ tablespoons of sultanas)

## Vegetables

*a standard serve is about 75g (100-350kJ)*

- ½ cup cooked green or orange vegetables e.g. broccoli, spinach, carrots, pumpkin
- ½ cup cooked, dried or canned beans, peas, lentils
- 1 cup green leafy or raw salad vegetables
- ½ cup sweet corn
- ½ medium potato or other starchy vegetables (sweet potato, taro or cassava)
- 1 tomato



# What constitutes as a serve?

## Dairy

*a standard serve is about 500-600kJ*

- 1 cup (250ml) milk (fresh, UHT long life, reconstituted powdered milk or buttermilk)
- 1 cup (250ml) soy, rice almond or other cereal-based milk, with at least 100mg of added calcium per 100ml
- ¾ cup (200g) yoghurt
- ½ cup evaporated milk
- 2 slices (40g) or 4 x 3 x 2 cm cube (40g) of hard cheese, such as cheddar
- ½ cup ricotta cheese

*choose mostly reduced fat



**If you do not eat any foods from this group, try the following foods, which contain about the same amount of calcium as a serve of milk, yogurt, cheese or alternatives (note: the kilojoule content of some of these serves (especially nuts is higher so watch this if trying to maintain a healthy gestational weight gain)**

- 100g almonds with skin
- 60g sardines, canned in water
- ½ cup (100g) canned pink salmon with bones
- 100g firm tofu (check the label as calcium levels vary)



## Meat and alternatives

*a standard serve is about 500-600kJ*

- 65g cooked lean red meats such as beef, lamb, veal, pork, goat or kangaroo (about 90-100g raw)
- 80g cooked lean poultry such as chicken or turkey (100g raw)
- 100g cooked fish fillet (about 115g raw) or one small can of fish
- 2 large (120g) eggs
- 1 cup (150g) cooked or canned legumes / beans such as lentils chickpeas or split peas
- 170g tofu
- 30g nuts, seeds, peanut or almond butter or tahini or other nut or seed paste*

*only to be used occasionally as a substitute for other foods in the group. Note: this amount for nuts and seeds gives approximately the same amount of energy

# How much weight should I gain through pregnancy

The amount of weight you gain during pregnancy can affect your own health as well as your baby's health and development.
According to the 2009 Institute of Medicine guidelines for gestational weight gain, which are used both internationally and in Australia, the amount of weight women should gain throughout their pregnancy depends on what your weight was before you became pregnant or your 'pre-pregnancy Body Mass Index (BMI)'.

## How to calculate your BMI:

Body mass index (BMI) is the number used to work out what the recommended amount is for you. You can work this out by following the steps below:

Pre-pregnancy weight: _____ kg  Height: _____ m (e.g. 165cm is 1.65 m)

$$\textbf{BMI} = \frac{\text{weight}}{\text{height}} = \frac{\text{kg}}{\text{m}^2}$$

Body mass index (BMI) is the number used to work out what the recommended amount is for you. You can work this out by following the steps below:

| Pre-pregnancy BMI | Recommended weight gain over the the whole pregnancy | Recommended weight gain per month in the 2nd and 3rd trimester* |
|---|---|---|
| less than 18.5kg/m2 (Underweight) | 12.5kg to 18.0kg | 2.0kg to 2.6kg |
| 18.5 – 24.9kg/m2 (Normal weight) | 11.5kg to 16.0kg | 1.5kg to 2.3kg |
| 25.0 - 29.9kg/m2 (Overweight)<br>23.0 - 27.5kg/m2 if Asian | 7.0kg to 11.5kg 1 | 1.0kg to 1.5kg |
| Above 30.0 kg/m2 (Obese)<br>Above 27.5 kg/m2 if Asian | 7.0kg to 11.5kg | 1.0kg to 1.5kg |

*Average gain in the first three months is 0.5kg to 2 kg for everyone.
Adapted from Institute of Medicine (2009)

The recommendations above are a guide only: there are circumstances where a different weight goal may be recommended by your midwife, doctor or dietitian.

Sounds daunting doesn't it? You may be thinking, it's too late, I'm already overweight or I've already gained more weight than I should have… well, the good news is, no, it's never too late to start making some healthier choices relating to your diet and lifestyle



# How to maintain a healthy weight during pregnancy

Steady, gradual weight gain during pregnancy is normal and important for the health of the mother and baby, however, gaining too much weight can increase your risk of adverse pregnancy and long-term health outcomes for you and your baby.

Maintaining a healthy weight during pregnancy improves pregnancy outcomes and can also help to improve yours and your baby's health now and in the future.

If you are pregnant, a good approach is to eat to satisfy your appetite and continue to monitor your weight.

If you are overweight or obese, pregnancy is not the time to start dieting or trying to lose weight. Weight gain within the recommended ranges is important to support the growth and development of your baby.

Small changes can make a big difference to both yours and your babies health. If you or your health professional believe you are gaining too much weight or believe you would like some support in managing your weight gain throughout your pregnancy, please talk to an accredited practicing dietitian or your doctor who can support you in your journey to manage your weight in a healthy and sustainable way

# How to maintain a healthy weight during pregnancy

## Factors that can influence how much weight you gain

- How and what you eat
- How active you are during your pregnancy
- Pregnancy related symptoms (nausea and fatigue)
- Changes to your appetite, for example food cravings and aversions
- Fluid retention

## How can I monitor my weight gain?

To help you monitor your weight gain, you can use this pregnancy weight tracker here: BMI less than 25kg/m2 (healthy weight) & BMI more than 25kg/m2 (above healthy weight). Just jump on the scales every-one to two weeks at home and plot your progress on the chart.

Getting continual feedback about how you are progressing and discussing this with your dietitian, doctor or midwife will help you to see if you are on the right track or need extra support in managing your weight gain.

## What if I am not gaining enough weight?

Check that you are:

Having three meals a day, and also having in between snacks such as morning tea, afternoon tea and supper. If you are concerned, talk to your dietitian, doctor or midwife about some strategies to help you increase your weight gain.

## What if I am gaining too much weight?

To control your weight gain, look more closely at what you are eating. Are you meeting all your nutrition needs? Answering these questions will help you to figure out why:

- Are your portion sizes too large?
- Are you eating too many discretionary foods?
- Are you drinking sugary drinks instead of water?
- Are you eating for two?
- Are you including regular exercise each day?



# Quick Tips to manage your weight during pregnancy

- Eat regular meals with a good variety of foods from the five food groups.
- If you are hungry, stop and grab a snack. Try easy snacks like those listed in the next section.
- Have one meal a day that has meat, chicken, eggs or fish with some salad or vegetables.
- Check your portion sizes.
- Limit your intake of limit discretionary foods and drinks high in saturated fat, added sugars and added salt such as cakes, biscuits, and sugary drinks.
- Choose low fat milk, yoghurt and cheese in place of full fat products.
- Remain active during your pregnancy.
- Ask a friend or family member to cook or shop for you in you can't do it yourself.
- Don't have too much tea, coffee or coke and avoid "energy" drinks, as they have too much caffeine. If you're thirsty, drink more water.
- If you don't eat fruit, then have a glass of orange juice and some salad or vegetables instead. If you don't eat vegetables, have fruit.



# Healthy Snack Ideas

A variety of good foods every day will provide the vitamins, minerals and nutrition you and your baby need

- Raisin toast
- Fresh fruit
- Dried fruit, nuts and seed mix
- Protein bliss balls
- Low fat or plain yoghurt with fresh fruit
- Muesli bars (for more protein, choose bars with nuts)
- Cheese and crackers
- Milk drinks (i.e. fruit smoothies, milo, milk, Ovaltine - try to choose low fat)
- Grainy bread with, avocado, vegemite, eggs, sardines, baked beans, peanut butter
- A bowl of cereal
- Raw fresh vegetables (celery, capsicum, carrot
- sticks) with dips (guacamole, hummus)
- Eggs (hard boiled)
- Soups
- Jacket potatoes
- Bean based high fibre cereal with milk
- Bean salad with tomatoes and cucumber
- Banana sandwich
- Ice cream, custard or yoghurt on fruit (try to choose low fat)
- Pasta with cheese and tomato sauce, beans or tuna
- Homemade pizza

So you've done your homework and read a lot of information from websites, health 'gurus', and magazines and news articles, but there is soooo much information, that it makes it difficult to know what to listen to and how to apply it… well, let me make things simple for you. I've done all the hard work and made sure that you will get all the nutrients you and your baby need in these meal plans.

No more stress, no more worry about whether you are on the right track, or if you're leaving anything out, eating too much, not eating enough.

**Check out these meal plans today so I can help you be the healthiest mumma you can be**

**Click here for Meal Plans**

# Frequently Asked Questions

## What foods should I avoid eating during pregnancy?

During pregnancy, a woman's immune system is lowered, so it is more difficult to fight off infection. Pregnant women have a higher risk of developing food -borne illness caused by listeria, campylobacter and salmonella. Pregnant women are also at risk of developing toxoplasmosis. Infection with these 'bugs' can be dangerous to the health of your baby, and can lead to premature birth, still birth or miscarriage. Therefore, mothers need to be more cautious about their food choices to keep their baby safe.

**Tips to avoid food borne illness during pregnancy:**

It is important to prepare and store food safely in pregnancy:

- Wash your hands before and after preparing food
- Keep your kitchen surfaces clean
- Ensure chopping boards and cooking utensils are clean when preparing food
- Do not let uncooked food contaminate cooked food
- Wash fruits, vegetables and salad before eating
- Cook food (especially meat) thoroughly
- Keep pets away from kitchen surfaces
- Wear disposable gloves if handling cat little or gardening
- Wash our hands after gardening or touching pets
- Store food at correct temperaturesDo not eat food past its used by date

A listeria infection is easily treated with antibiotics, but prevention is best. Some foods are more prone to contamination with listeria than others and should be avoided if you are pregnant. Reduce the risk of listeria infection by eating foods that have been freshly cooked or prepared.

Avoid:

- Buffets, salad bars and sandwich bars
- Meats that are raw or undercooked
- Cold deli meats, packaged / ready to eat meats including cooked cold ready to eat (unless reheated until steaming hot)
- Pre-packaged or pre-prepared fruits and vegetables
- Chilled seafood e.g. raw oysters, sashimi, sushi, and cooked chilled prawns or smoked salmon
- Soft cheese like brie, camembert, fetta and ricotta (safe if cooked and hot)
- Unpasteurised milk products and juices
- Refrigerated pate, meat spreads or smoked seafood
- Raw or undercooked eggs
- Raw sprouts
- Soft serve ice cream

Listeria is killed by cooking, so make sure that when you reheat food, it is very hot.

Salmonella is a cause of food poisoning that can trigger miscarriage. The most likely sources of salmonella are raw eggs and undercooked meat and poultry.

# Frequently Asked Questions

## Vitamin and mineral supplementation for pregnancy

Even where choosing nutrition foods, it can be difficult to get enough of all the essential nutrients you need from your diet alone. It is therefore recommended that all women who are pregnant take a pregnancy multivitamin supplement each day in addition to a healthy diet. This will help to ensure you are getting enough of the key nutrients for your baby's development.

## What types of fish are safe to eat during pregnancy?

Eating fish once or twice a week during your pregnancy is a great aim as it is high in protein and high in omega-3 essential fatty acids which your body and baby can benefit from during pregnancy. It's important however, that you limit your consumption of some specific fish types that are high in mercury as these fish may affect the developing nervous system of unborn babies and infants.

**The types of fish that you need to limit include:**

- Shark (flake), broadbill, marlin, and sword fish should be eaten only once per fortnight with no other fish that fortnight
- Orange roughy (sea perch) and catfish should be eaten no more than once per week, with no other fish that week
- Any other fish not mentioned above may be eaten safely two to three times per week.

*Pregnant women are encouraged to eat 150g fish twice a week, but to avoid exposing your unborn child to excessive mercury. Choose fish like sardines, salmon, herring and trout. They pack a mean omega-3 punch, but are low risk for mercury.*

## Can I drink alcohol when I am pregnant?

There is no known safe level of alcohol consumption for women who are pregnant. Consuming alcohol during pregnancy increases the risk of miscarriage, low birth weight, congenital deformities and effects on the baby's intelligence. The Australian guidelines to reduce health risks from drinking alcohol recommend that the safest option for pregnant women is not to drink alcohol at all.

If you find it difficult to decrease or stop drinking alcohol during pregnancy, talk to your doctor or midwife, your local community health services, or an alcohol and other drug helpline in your state or territory.

# Frequently Asked Questions

## Can I have drinks containing caffeine?

There are a number of good reasons backed by science for why consuming caffeine is a bad idea when you are pregnant. Firstly, caffeine is a stimulant. It increases your blood pressure and heart rate, both of which can be dangerous to you and your baby. It is also a diuretic, meaning it increases the amount of times you need to urinate and as a result, can lead to dehydration. Last but not least, caffeine crosses the placenta to your baby, so although you may be able to handle the amounts of caffeine you feed your body, your baby cannot metabolise the caffeine yet, and therefore any amount of caffeine can affect your baby's development, sleep patterns and movement patterns. Therefore, the bottom line is the less caffeine you consume, the better.

Remember that caffeine is found in more than just coffee. It is also found in tea, some soft drinks, energy drinks and chocolate so be aware of what you consume.

## What about food cravings?

If you find you're craving certain foods, there is usually no reason why you can't indulge a little – but pregnancy isn't an excuse to go overboard on treats! Contrary to popular belief, food cravings are not an indication of what your body needs. Choose nutrient-dense foods like fresh and dried fruit, nuts, frozen yoghurt and lean protein to counter the cravings. Limit foods containing empty calories, like soft drink, sweets and fried foods. Pregnancy is a time to make every mouthful count and nutrient-rich foods will benefit your baby and keep you healthy

## How can I meet all my nutritional needs if I don't eat certain foods i.e. I am a Vegetarian or Vegan, or I have food allergies and intolerances?

Getting all the nutrition you and your baby need during pregnancy when you are avoiding certain foods can be challenging at the best of times. When you are pregnant, your nutritional requirements significantly increase to successfully support and grow a healthy baby. If you are limiting or avoiding foods that provide a major source of nutrition such as meat, dairy, fish, or breads and cereals (gluten or wheat), it is vital that you replace the nutrition that these core foods provide with alternative sources that have similar nutritional properties to the food/s you are eliminating.

## What if I don't consume dairy?

Dairy foods are a major source of protein and our biggest source of calcium which is needed to build your baby's skeletal, heart and neuromuscular systems. Women who consume little or no dairy, need to make sure that they include enough calcium each day from other non-dairy sources such as bony fish (sardines, salmon), legumes, chia seeds, nuts (almonds), green vegetables (spinach, kale, broccoli), and fortified soy beverages, breakfast cereals, juices, and breads. It's a good idea to check the labels of dairy alternatives such as soy, rice, almond and oat milks to ensure they are fortified with calcium, with soy being the most nutritionally like dairy.

Calcium (Ca) and iron (Fe) compete for absorption so if your levels in either of these nutrients are low, try to avoid consuming foods that are high in these nutrients together.

# Frequently Asked Questions

## What if I don't eat meat, eggs, or fish?

Red meat, poultry, fish, eggs, and plant source meat alternatives (legumes, tofu, nuts and seeds) are essential for providing our bodies with protein for growth and cell repair, and vitamins and minerals such as iron and niacin for energy, vitamin B12 for good memory and omega fatty 3 acids for healthy heart and brain development.

Proteins are made up of amino acids. Some amino acids can be made from the body, but others, called 'essential amino acids', must be derived from the foods we eat.

Foods that contain all essential amino acids are called 'high quality' or 'complete' protein foods and include eggs, meat, fish, poultry and dairy products (animal sources).

Some foods of plant origin contain protein, but these plant-based foods do not contain all the essential amino acids and are called 'incomplete' protein foods.

If you are a vegetarian or vegan, it is vital for you to eat a wide variety of plant-based proteins each day and to combine different essential amino acids together in a meal, for example: corn plus beans, cereal products (rice, pasta, breads) plus seeds and nuts, dried beans plus seeds and nuts or dried beans plus cereal products. Including a variety of these plant-based protein sources in your daily diet along with plenty of fresh vegetables, fruits, dairy, and unsaturated fats and oils will help you to meet your nutritional requirements.

If in doubt, consult an Accredited Practicing Dietitian to ensure your diet is nutritionally adequate.

## What if I don't eat gluten or wheat?

Gluten is found in many foods and most commonly, in grains and cereals such as wheat, barley, rye, oats and triticale.

Grains and cereals are a key source of carbohydrates which are the body's favourite source of fuel as they are easy to break down and provide 16kj of energy per gram. They also provide a host of other nutrients that your body needs to successfully support the growth and development of your baby such as protein, fibre, vitamin B, iron, zinc, magnesium, and folate.

If you are unable to consume gluten or wheat, it is imperative to ensure you are getting enough energy and nutrition from alternative grains and unrefined cereals such as maize/ corn, rice, sago, tapioca/arrowroot, buckwheat, millet, amaranth, quinoa, potato, soy, legumes, lentils.

Aim to make these the basis of a healthy diet along with unprocessed meat, poultry and eggs, fresh and frozen fruits and vegetables, unflavoured dairy milk or non-dairy alternatives, nuts, legumes and lentils and unsaturated fats & oils.

# Frequently Asked Questions

## Other nutritional concerns

During pregnancy, there are substances that you need to eliminate that can cause harm to your baby. These include tobacco smoke, drug use and alcohol.

## Main Take Away

In a nutshell, if you are limiting or avoiding particular foods by choice or necessity, it is important that you check your dietary intake with an Accredited Practicing Dietitian. Depending on your medical and family history, health risk factors, dietary intake, and individual requirements, you may need additional guidance and support to help you meet both yours and your baby's nutritional needs.



# A Note from Kat

I'm here to tell you not to be anxious. You can rest assured that everyone entering pregnancy has a myriad of emotions. As exciting and overwhelming as it can feel, just by reading this, you are on the right track to taking the best care of your and your baby's health, now and in the future.

Even better, you have come to the right place for information on how to care for you and your baby. This guide provides you withscientifically sound nutritional advice from an accredited practicing dietician who has completed over 12 years of university and post graduate education, 8 in the field of nutrition, and 4 specifically in the field of prenatal nutrition.

The great news is that I have done all the hard work for you and present the most up to date, reliable and valid nutrition advice you could receive. This means, you can trust what you are read, and if you follow the advice presented in this guide, you will be off to a great start in giving your baby a lifetime of good health.

So, is nutrition important in pregnancy…surely what you eat can't really affect the babies or your health can it?

The answer is a massive **YES!** Pregnancy is a unique window of time where what you eat can impact not only on your own health but also your baby's health, and the health of your baby's babies. Yes, you read that correctly… pregnancy is a unique OPPORTUNITY for you to reset your own health and the health of your family and future generations!



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